

Money Mistake: You're Dating a Gold Digger

THE FIX: GET A PRENUP

Whether you've weathered an awful divorce or never managed to walk down the aisle to begin with, one of the biggest threats to midlife wealth is people who are after your money: namely, gold diggers. And they're not just for the wealthy to worry about. Anytime there is financial disparity of any kind between a couple, caution must be exercised. If you have a healthy pension, you'd be wise to date someone equally flush in the twilight years.

Then there is the obvious gold digger, the one purely trading youth and beauty for a bit of financial security and bling. I've met a few gold diggers in my travels, both female and male. Some of them are perfectly nice people, but they have a single goal in mind: to meet and marry someone rich. Note: There's a big difference between someone who's concerned about his or her financial health and a gold digger who's interested only in your financial wealth. But the only surefire way to "out" a gold digger is to slap a prenuptial agreement down in front of him or her.

Case in point: I ran into an old acquaintance of mine in New York when my wife and I were attending a party a while ago. My acquaintance is a handsome guy in his midfifties who made his fortune in software, just like I did. Ten years ago, he left his wife and remarried, a union that lasted less than two years and led to a split that cost him hundreds of thousands of dollars. After vowing never to marry again, he then began dating only young, beautiful women who stayed with him as long as the money flowed. These women (classic gold diggers) scrutinized the society pages the way I scrutinize stock prices.

At the party, this acquaintance introduced my wife and me to his latest companion, a bored, leggy redhead decades his junior. After some small talk, the acquaintance and I made plans to catch up over dinner when I was back in New York. A few weeks later, settling into our booth at a swanky steakhouse, I asked about the redhead.